AN INDEPENDENT PROJECT BY THACH NGUYEN

Practices that kept their names. And lost their jobs.

Twelve case files. Each names a signal, the condition behind it, one change to try, and what to look for afterward.

ALL CASE FILES ARE FICTIONAL. ANY RESEMBLANCE TO YOUR LAST SPRINT IS COINCIDENTAL.

Choose one case that sounds familiar. Read the four findings when you want the patterns beneath them. Filed by the Cult of Clarity.

Chapter I. Ceremonies

Four rituals investigated. Attendance was excellent.

Case 001 / The Sprint That Planned Itself

SUBJECT Sprint planning

SIGNAL “We’ll figure out scope during the sprint.” The board has work, but the team cannot name a shared outcome.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING The team is asked to commit to tickets before an open decision is made.

TRY Agree on the sprint goal and what can wait. Put the unresolved choice with the person who can make it before treating the list as a commitment.

LOOK FOR Can three teammates describe the same goal and what would make it change?

Case 002 / The Standup That Would Not End

SUBJECT Daily standup

SIGNAL “Yesterday I... Today I... No blockers.” The room gets an update; the plan stays untouched.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING The meeting rewards a complete recital instead of useful coordination.

TRY Ask what changed since yesterday, what is at risk, and who needs to coordinate. Move detailed problem-solving to the people involved.

LOOK FOR Did anyone get unblocked or adjust the plan?

Case 003 / The Retro That Solved Nothing

SUBJECT Sprint retrospective

SIGNAL The same concern appears on new sticky notes. Nothing changes by the next sprint.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING Concerns are collected, but no change is chosen. Some may be difficult to raise safely in the room.

TRY Choose one change within the team’s reach, name who will take it forward, and check it at the next retro. Route concerns that need outside authority without asking someone to defend a sensitive issue in public.

LOOK FOR Was the change tried? Did it help?

Case 004 / The Demo That Demoed a Prototype of a Demo

SUBJECT Sprint review

SIGNAL "Please imagine this is clickable." A deck presents a prototype as delivered work.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING The review is expected to look finished, so the difference between completed work and learning gets blurred.

TRY Show completed work as completed, prototypes as experiments, and unresolved work as unresolved. Use the review to decide what to adapt next.

LOOK FOR Did the review reveal an assumption or change a decision?

Chapter II. Roles and incentives

The role gets a title. The system decides what it can do.

Case 005 / The Customer Voice on Mute

SUBJECT Product Owner and customer evidence

SIGNAL A decision is made on behalf of customers, but no current customer evidence reaches the team.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING Research, support, frontline, and direct customer signals have no reliable path into planning. One role is left to improvise "the voice."

TRY Bring one relevant, recent customer signal to the decision. Mark what remains an assumption and how the consequential unknowns could be tested.

LOOK FOR Did the evidence change the choice or clarify what is still unknown?

Case 006 / The Ceremony That Outlived Its Reason

SUBJECT Scrum Master and team ceremonies

SIGNAL Everyone attends. Nobody can say what the meeting should decide, learn, or protect.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING The calendar invite has an owner; its purpose does not.

TRY State the expected output and any quality or governance need it serves. Shorten or redesign the meeting. Retire it if it is optional and serves no distinct purpose.

LOOK FOR Did the team preserve the needed decision, record, or safeguard with less time?

Case 007 / The Release That Became the Result

SUBJECT Delivery Lead and outcome measures

SIGNAL The release is counted as success. Nobody checks whether people can use what shipped, or whether it helped.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING Delivery is easier to report than the outcome the work was meant to improve.

TRY Pair release status with one meaningful use or outcome signal. Set a date to inspect it, even if the first measure is an imperfect proxy.

LOOK FOR Did the signal change the next investment or reveal a question worth investigating?

Case 008 / The Override That Arrived in Sprint Six

SUBJECT Stakeholder access and scope decisions

SIGNAL A late request changes the plan. Nobody names what now waits.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING Stakeholders and risk partners entered after the trade-offs became expensive, and decision rights remained vague.

TRY Record who can change priority, what new evidence or obligation warrants it, and which work moves out. Welcome late customer, safety, or regulatory facts. Make their cost and importance visible.

LOOK FOR Can the team explain why the change was made and what it displaced?

Chapter III. Tools and templates

Four artifacts recovered. None can speak for itself.

Case 009 / The Poster That Time Forgot

SUBJECT Definition of Done

SIGNAL The criteria are on the wall. The team does not use them to decide whether work is complete.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING The criteria were not revisited as the team, product, and requirements changed.

TRY Review them with the team and anyone accountable for quality or required controls. Retain required safeguards, revise obsolete steps, and use the result on the next item.

LOOK FOR Does completed work meet shared criteria without a last-minute surprise?

Case 010 / The Chart Nobody Read

SUBJECT Burndown chart

SIGNAL The chart is produced every sprint and opened only after the deadline slips.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING It appears in reporting, but no decision uses it.

TRY For the next two sprints, ask what decision the chart changes. If it changes none, retire it or replace it with a signal the team can use.

LOOK FOR Did it help the team see a risk early enough to respond?

Case 011 / The Score That Was Not a Score

SUBJECT Velocity

SIGNAL Story points are used to rank teams or assess a person's performance.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING A planning estimate became a target, changing what the number rewards.

TRY Use velocity, if useful, for planning within the team. Keep story points out of individual appraisal. Consider delivery alongside evidence of quality and value.

LOOK FOR Do estimates help the team plan without rewarding point inflation?

Case 012 / The Board That Never Moved

SUBJECT Shared work board

SIGNAL Most work sits in “In Progress” or “Blocked.” The standup proceeds from the board as if it were current.

WHAT KEEPS IT GOING The board serves upward reporting more reliably than team coordination.

TRY Ask the people doing the work what is moving and what is stuck. Update the shared board together. Name the decision or support each blocked item needs.

LOOK FOR Can someone use the board to help sooner?

Chapter IV. Findings

Four truths recovered

01 **Rituals need a job.** A ceremony should make a decision clearer, expose a risk, or help the team learn. Attendance is not an outcome.

02 **Roles need the conditions to succeed.** Customer access, decision rights, and permission to raise a concern cannot be supplied by a job title. Fix the condition before blaming the person.

03 **Artifacts need to match reality.** A board, chart, or Definition of Done earns its place when people can use it to see progress, risk, or quality while there is time to act.

04 **A familiar joke is a clue.** When everyone recognizes the pattern, ask what rewards it, what makes it hard to challenge, and who can change one condition. Then check what happened.

Chapter V. Close of file

Twelve cases. One standard.

For any practice or artifact, ask what decision it improves, what learning it enables, or what quality it protects. Then ask whether it did that job.

Choose one case that looks familiar. Name the condition keeping it alive, one change within reach, who will take it forward, and when to revisit the result.

File remains open until the work changes.

Use one case

Pick one familiar pattern. Make one change within reach, then check what happened.

CASE AND SIGNAL WE CAN SEE

CONDITION KEEPING IT GOING

ONE CHANGE TO TRY AND WHO WILL TAKE IT FORWARD

WHEN TO REVISIT AND WHAT TO LOOK FOR